100% free tools | Official Instagram API | n8n

Instagram Auto DM for Reels

Someone comments on your reel → they automatically get your link in DM, and their comment gets a "Check your DM 📩" reply. Like ManyChat, but free and fully yours.

Made by **@nikhilisobsessed** on Instagram — follow for more free automations 🔥 · Template file: **instagram_auto_dm_template.json**

1. What it does

💬 Comment → DM
Anyone who comments on your reel (any comment, or a keyword like `link`) gets your message in their DMs.

📩 Public reply
Their comment gets a reply like "Thanks for comment ❤️ Check your DM 📩" — this boosts engagement too.

🛡️ Safe by default
1 DM per person per reel, max 150 DMs per hour, and a random 4–15 second delay so it looks human.

♻️ Set and forget
The Instagram token refreshes itself every Monday, so it never expires. Add new reels with a simple form.

2. How it works

Viewer comments → n8n checks reels every 1 min → Reel + keyword match? → Safety checks → Send DM → Reply to comment → Save in log

1. **Find new comments.** Every minute, n8n reads the latest comments on your active reels using the official Instagram API. It only looks at comments from the last 15 minutes that it hasn't handled yet.
2. **Match.** It checks which reel the comment is on and whether it contains your keyword (`*` means any comment).
3. **Safety checks.** It skips your own comments, skips people who already got the DM for that reel, and stops if you hit the hourly limit.
4. **Send.** After a short random wait, it sends a *private reply* — Instagram's official "reply to a comment by DM" feature. It lands in the viewer's message requests.
5. **Reply + log.** It posts your public reply under the comment and saves everything in a log table, so you can see who got what.

> **Why polling every minute?** Instagram can also push comments instantly with "webhooks", but Meta only sends those to apps that passed App Review. Polling works right away for everyone, no review needed. The template has both — webhooks start working automatically if you ever get App Review.

3. What you need (all free)

Thing	Why	Cost
Instagram **Professional** account (Creator or Business)	The Instagram API only works with professional accounts	Free
Meta for Developers account (developers.facebook.com)	To create the app that gives n8n permission	Free
n8n (self-hosted, n8n cloud, or any n8n host)	Runs the automation 24/7. Needs the **Data tables** feature	Free if self-hosted
A **privacy policy** web page	Meta requires it before you can publish the app	Free (GitHub Pages / Google Sites)

4. Setup, step by step

Part A — Instagram

1. In the Instagram app: **Settings** → **Account type and tools** → **Switch to professional account** (Creator is fine).
2. Make sure messages from apps are allowed: **Settings** → **Messages and story replies** → **Message controls** → **Connected tools** → **Allow access to messages** = ON.

Part B — Meta app

3. Go to **developers.facebook.com** → **My Apps** → **Create App**. Pick the use case **"Manage messaging & content on Instagram"**, give it a name (e.g. *Comment AutoReply Bot*) and create it.
4. Open **Use cases** → **Customize** → **Permissions and features** and click **Add** on all three: `instagram_business_basic`, `instagram_business_manage_comments`, `instagram_business_manage_messages`.

   > Don't skip **manage_comments** — without it the app can't see comments and nothing happens.

5. Open **API setup with Instagram login** → **2. Generate access tokens** → **Add account**, log in with your Instagram, then click **Generate token**. Copy the token (starts with `IGAA…`). Keep it secret — it's like a password.
6. **App settings** → **Basic**: add your **Privacy policy URL**, the same link as **User data deletion** URL, choose a **Category** (Messaging) → **Save changes**.
7. Click **Publish** in the left menu → **Publish**. The status should change from "Unpublished" to **Published**.

Part C — n8n data tables

8. In n8n go to **Overview** → **Data tables** → **Create** and make these three tables with these exact column names:

Table	Columns (name · type)
IG AutoDM Settings	`ig_user_id` text · `ig_username` text · `access_token` text · `verify_token` text · `max_dms_per_hour` number · `min_delay_sec` number · `max_delay_sec` number · `token_refreshed_at` date
IG AutoDM Reels	`reel_url` text · `keyword` text · `dm_message` text · `public_reply` text · `active` boolean · `media_id` text · `note` text · `link` text
IG AutoDM Log	`comment_id` text · `media_id` text · `user_id` text · `username` text · `keyword` text · `comment_text` text · `status` text · `error` text · `sent_at` date

9. In **IG AutoDM Settings** add **one row**: `max_dms_per_hour` = 150, `min_delay_sec` = 4, `max_delay_sec` = 15, `verify_token` = any random word (e.g. `my-secret-123`). Leave the rest empty — the Connect form fills them.

Part D — Import the workflow

10. In n8n: **Create workflow** → ⋯ **menu** → **Import from file** → choose `instagram_auto_dm_template.json`.
11. Open **every Data table node** (they show a warning) and select the matching table from the list. The node's old table name is shown as a hint.
12. **Save** and click **Publish** (top right) so it runs 24/7.

Part E — Connect and add your reel

13. Open `https://YOUR-N8N-URL/form/ig-auto-dm-connect` (log in to n8n first), paste your Instagram token, click **Connect**. You should see **"Connected ✅ @yourname"**.
14. Open `https://YOUR-N8N-URL/form/ig-auto-dm-add-reel` and fill in the reel link, keyword, link and messages (see section 5). Click **Add reel**.
15. **Test:** comment on that reel from a **different** Instagram account. Within about 1 minute you should get the DM (check *Message requests*) and see the public reply.

5. Writing your messages

Field	What to write	Example
Reel link	The reel URL, or `ALL` to cover your 10 newest posts	`https://www.instagram.com/reel/ABC123/`
Keyword(s)	Words that trigger the DM, separated by commas. `*` = any comment	`link, guide, n8n` or `*`
Link to send	Used wherever you write `{link}`	`https://github.com/…`
DM message	Use `{username}` and `{link}`. Separate variations with `||` — one is picked at random so every DM looks a bit different	`Hey @{username} 👋 Here's your link: {link} || Hi @{username}! Link 👉 {link}`
Public reply (optional)	Reply posted under the comment. Also supports `||` variations	`Thanks for comment ❤️ Check your DM 📩`

> **Changing a reel later?** Just add the same reel again with the new text — the newest entry always wins. To stop a reel, set `active` to false in the Reels table.

6. Rules & limits to know

- Instagram allows **one private reply per comment**, within **7 days** of the comment.
- The DM arrives in the viewer's **Message requests** until they reply or accept.
- Only comments from the **last 15 minutes** are picked up, so old comments won't suddenly get DMs when you add a reel.
- Keep it useful, not spammy — only send what you promised in the reel. Spammy DMs can get your account restricted.
- The workflow runs about 1,440 small checks per day. On a hosted n8n plan with execution limits, change ⏱️ **Every Minute** to 2–5 minutes.

7. Troubleshooting

Problem	Fix
Nothing happens after a comment	Check the workflow is **Published**, the reel is **active**, the keyword matches, and you commented from a **different** account (your own comments are ignored).
Connect form says error	Token is wrong or expired — generate a new one in Meta (step 5) and paste again.
Comments show but no DM	Make sure `instagram_business_manage_comments` and `manage_messages` are added, then **generate a new token** (old tokens don't get new permissions).
Log says `skip_duplicate`	Normal — that person already got the DM for this reel.
Log says `failed`	Open the `error` column. "User not found" = comment was deleted. Also check "Allow access to messages" (step 2).
Instagram API says "unknown error" (500)	Instagram sometimes returns this even though the DM was delivered. The template counts it as sent, so nobody gets a double DM.

8. Optional: instant webhooks

Not needed for the polling setup above. Useful only if your app gets Meta App Review (Advanced Access).

In Meta: **API setup with Instagram login** → **3. Configure webhooks** → Callback URL `https://YOUR-N8N-URL/webhook/ig-auto-dm`, Verify token = the `verify_token` from your Settings table → **Verify and save** → subscribe to **comments**. Turn the account's **Webhook Subscription** switch On.

Original guide by @nikhilisobsessed on Instagram. Built with n8n + the official Instagram API (Instagram Login). Not affiliated with Meta or Instagram. Follow Instagram's Platform Terms and Community Guidelines.